Immutable and Mortal

Publications as Timestamps and the Death of Patching

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I. ABSTRACT

This paper establishes that a scientific publication is an immutable timestamp — a fixed commitment made at a specific moment in the history of investigation, stating what was claimed, when it was claimed, and on what basis. Publications are born when submitted, live as active claims subject to falsification, die when falsified, and remain in the record as permanent markers of explored territory. They do not get edited into correctness.

We demonstrate that the institutional practice of patching — modifying published claims through errata, revised analyses, added parameters, or narrowed conclusions — constitutes retroactive infallibility. The institution is never wrong because the record is edited until it matches reality. We show that a claim that can be modified after the fact until it matches observation is not a hypothesis but a prophecy, and that prophecies are unfalsifiable by the institution's own demarcation criterion.

We establish the standard: wrong means dead. Dead means the publication remains in the record, marked as falsified, pointing to what killed it. Replacement means a new publication that stands on the falsification, references the dead paper, and makes a new claim informed by the boundary the death revealed. The dead paper's presence in the record is not a mark of shame. It is a boundary marker — the most valuable kind of information science produces. Removing the corpse removes the warning. Editing the corpse pretends the death never happened. The honest standard preserves the corpse because the corpse is the map.

II. WHAT A PUBLICATION IS

A publication is a timestamp. It records a commitment made at a specific coordinate in the history of investigation.

At this date. By this investigator. Using this method. Based on this evidence. This claim is made.

The claim is now fixed in time. It is testable against reality from the moment of publication forward. It can be confirmed, extended, replicated, or falsified. Each of these outcomes is a subsequent timestamp — a new coordinate on the map of explored territory that references the original.

The publication's function is to be a coordinate. Coordinates do not move. A coordinate says: at this point in time, this was the state of knowledge. This is what was tried. This is what was found. This is what was claimed. The coordinate is permanent regardless of whether the claim turns out to be correct.

A correct coordinate marks where something was found. An incorrect coordinate marks where something was tried and failed. Both are information. Both contribute to the map. A map with only correct coordinates is a map with no boundaries. A map with no boundaries is a brochure, not a map. The incorrect coordinates — the places where investigators tried something and it did not work — are what give the map its shape.

Moving a coordinate to where it should have been is not correction. It is falsification of the record. The coordinate was here. Moving it there changes the historical fact of where the investigation stood at that moment. The record no longer reflects what happened. It reflects what should have happened. The map is now fiction.

III. WHAT DEATH MEANS

A falsified publication is dead. The claim as stated does not hold. Reality has provided a counterexample, a failed prediction, a non-replicating result, or an internal contradiction.

Death does not mean removal. The publication remains in the record. It is marked as falsified. It points to what killed it — the specific counterexample, the specific failed prediction, the specific paper that documented the failure. The pointer is permanent. Anyone who encounters the dead publication can follow the pointer to understand what went wrong and why.

The death is information. The death may be the most valuable information the publication ever produced. A living publication says: this approach works, this claim holds, this territory is mapped. A dead publication says: this approach was tried, this claim was tested, and here is the specific point where it failed. The failure point is a boundary. The boundary tells the next investigator where not to look. The boundary tells the next investigator what the previous approach could not handle. The boundary tells the next investigator what the replacement must address.

A record full of dead publications with clear falsification markers is a map of extraordinary value. It shows the full territory of exploration — the successes and the failures, the landmarks and the dead ends, the places where knowledge holds and the places where it breaks. An investigator entering a field with access to this record knows immediately what has been tried, what failed, and why. The investigator starts from the boundary of explored territory rather than from zero.

A record from which dead publications have been removed or edited into correctness provides none of this. The investigator entering the field sees only successes. The failures are invisible. The boundaries are hidden. The investigator may repeat a failure that was documented, killed, and then edited out of existence. The investigation starts from zero because the map has been stripped of its most informative features.

IV. WHAT REPLACEMENT MEANS

When a publication dies, the replacement is a new publication. Not an edit. Not a revision. Not an updated version. A new publication with its own timestamp, its own claims, and its own basis.

The new publication references the dead one. It says: this previous paper claimed X. X was falsified because of Y. The falsification reveals boundary Z. Based on Z, I now claim W. Here is my evidence. Here is how to test W. Here is what opens up if W holds. Here is what opens up if W fails.

The new publication stands on the dead paper's grave. It exists because the dead paper found the boundary. Both papers are in the record. Both are information. The dead paper shows what was tried and where it failed. The new paper shows what the failure taught and where the investigation went next.

The chain is visible. Any reader can trace the path: original claim, falsification, boundary, new claim. The history of the investigation is preserved. The wrong turns are visible. The corrections are visible. The progression from error to understanding is documented as a sequence of timestamps, each one a fixed coordinate that does not move.

This chain is what the institutional record should look like. Not a series of papers that were always correct, but a series of papers that trace the path of investigation through successes and failures alike. The failures are not embarrassments in this record. They are essential links in the chain. Without them, the chain has no structure. Without them, the reader does not know why the current claim is shaped the way it is — what previous approaches failed and what those failures revealed.

V. WHAT PATCHING IS

Patching is the modification of a published claim to accommodate evidence that contradicts the original assertion.

The forms of patching vary. A predicted value is revised when measurement disagrees. A conclusion is narrowed when exceptions are found. Parameters are added when the existing framework cannot fit the data. Scope is reduced when a universal claim encounters counterexamples. Analysis is updated when the original statistical method is found to be inadequate.

Each of these modifications changes what the paper claims. The paper before the modification and the paper after the modification make different assertions. The pre-modification version was wrong — it claimed something that does not hold. The post-modification version is a different paper. It makes different claims on the same evidence base, or the same claims on a different evidence base, or narrower claims that avoid the falsification of the original.

The post-modification version wears the same citation as the pre-modification version. The same DOI. The same reference in every paper that cited the original. Readers who cited the original — the version that was wrong — now appear to have cited the revised version, the version that is less wrong. The citation history is corrupted. The record of who relied on what has been altered without the knowledge or consent of the researchers who made the citations.

The pre-modification version — the one that was wrong — has been overwritten. It no longer exists in the record as a separate coordinate. The failure it represents has been absorbed into the revision. The boundary it revealed has been hidden behind the patch. The next investigator who encounters this paper sees a paper that was always correct within its revised scope, not a paper that was wrong and then fixed.

The map has lost a coordinate. The boundary has been erased. The error that would have told the next investigator where not to look has been edited into a success that tells the next investigator nothing about the shape of the explored territory.

VI. RETROACTIVE INFALLIBILITY

The cumulative effect of patching is an institution that is never wrong.

Not because the institution does not make errors. The institution makes errors constantly — this is the normal operation of investigation, the expected outcome of testing claims against reality. Errors are how boundaries are found. Errors are the primary mechanism of scientific progress.

The institution is never wrong because the errors are edited out of the record. The publication is modified. The claim is revised. The scope is narrowed. The parameter is added. The revision is presented as a correction — a minor update to an essentially correct paper — rather than as an admission that the original claim was wrong.

Over time, the institutional record accumulates revisions. Each revision makes the record appear more correct. The appearance is accurate — the revised papers are closer to reality than the originals. But the record of how the institution got there — the wrong turns, the failed predictions, the overstatements, the boundaries — has been erased. The record shows a discipline that was always approximately correct and got progressively more precise. It does not show a discipline that was frequently wrong and corrected itself through a series of falsifications.

The difference matters. A discipline that was always approximately correct is a discipline that does not need falsification. Its method is refinement — incremental improvement of already-correct claims. A discipline that was frequently wrong and corrected itself through falsification is a discipline whose method is what the institution claims: attempted disconfirmation. The patched record is consistent with the first narrative. The honest record — the one with the dead papers, the boundary markers, the falsification chains — is consistent with the second.

The institution claims the second narrative. The institution maintains the first record. The record and the narrative do not match. The patching is the mechanism of the mismatch.

VII. THE PROPHECY PROBLEM

A claim that can be modified after the fact until it matches observation is not a hypothesis. It is a prophecy.

A hypothesis makes a specific prediction. The prediction is tested. The hypothesis lives or dies based on the outcome. The specificity of the prediction is what makes the hypothesis falsifiable. "The mass will be 2.1" is falsifiable — measure the mass, compare to 2.1, the hypothesis lives or dies. "The mass will be approximately what we measure" is not falsifiable — any measurement confirms it.

A patched publication operates like the second formulation. The original paper claims 2.1. The measurement shows 2.2. The paper is revised to claim 2.2, or to claim "approximately 2," or to add a correction factor that produces 2.2 from the original formalism. The paper now matches observation. The paper "predicted" the observation — after the observation was made and the paper was edited to match.

This is prophecy. The prophet says something ambiguous. The event occurs. The prophecy is reinterpreted to match the event. The prophet is declared correct. The reinterpretation is presented as the original meaning. The record shows a successful prediction.

The institution's own demarcation criterion — the standard by which it distinguishes science from pseudoscience — is falsifiability. A claim is scientific if it can be shown to be wrong. A claim that can be edited after the fact to match any observation cannot be shown to be wrong. It is unfalsifiable. By the institution's own standard, a patched publication is not science. It is the thing the institution defines itself against.

The institution that patches its publications has converted its hypotheses into prophecies while claiming that its defining feature is the submission of hypotheses to falsification. The conversion is not announced. The record does not distinguish between papers that predicted correctly and papers that were edited to match. Both appear as correct predictions. Both carry the same evidential weight. The prophecy and the hypothesis are indistinguishable in the patched record.

VIII. THE NEPTUNE EXAMPLE

The discovery of Neptune illustrates the honest standard practiced correctly.

The original claim: these are the planets and this is how they move. Newtonian mechanics applied to the known planets predicts specific orbits. The claim is a timestamp — at this date, this is our model of the solar system.

The observation: Uranus does not move as predicted. The orbit deviates from the model's predictions. The claim as stated is falsified. The model said Uranus would be here. Uranus is there. The prediction failed.

The falsification is published. The boundary is visible: the current model of the solar system does not account for Uranus's actual orbit. Something the model does not include is affecting the orbit. The boundary points at a specific location — not metaphorically but literally. The discrepancy in Uranus's orbit, analyzed mathematically, points to a specific region of the sky where an unaccounted mass would explain the deviation.

A new investigation, standing on the falsification, predicts Neptune. The prediction is tested. Neptune is found. The discovery exists because the falsification was accepted and the boundary was visible.

Now consider the patched version. The original model fails to predict Uranus's orbit. The model is "corrected" — a new planet is added to the model and the paper is revised to include Neptune. The revised paper now correctly predicts all known planetary orbits. The original error — the failure that pointed at Neptune — has been edited out. The record shows a model that always included Neptune. The discovery of Neptune appears not as the result of a falsification chain but as a feature of a model that was always approximately correct.

The patched version erases the path. The falsification was the discovery. The error in the original model was the information that led to Neptune. Removing the error from the record removes the evidence that the error was productive. The next investigator reading the patched record does not learn that falsification led to discovery. The next investigator learns that the model was always close to correct and got refined over time. The narrative changes from "we were wrong and the wrongness taught us something" to "we were always right, just imprecisely."

The first narrative is science. The second is institutional mythology.

IX. THE SLOW DRIFT

The most insidious form of patching is the gradual narrowing of claims through successive modifications until the claim is trivially true and unfalsifiable.

A paper claims: “All X are Y.” A counterexample is found — an X that is not Y. The paper is revised: “Most X are Y.” Another counterexample is found — a context in which most X are not Y. The paper is revised: “Some X are Y under certain conditions.” Another counterexample is found. The paper is revised: “X and Y are sometimes associated in specific contexts when certain conditions obtain.”

The final version is trivially true. It claims almost nothing. It is immune to falsification because its scope has been narrowed until no observation could contradict it. The paper has drifted from a bold, testable, falsifiable claim to a cautious, untestable, unfalsifiable one — through a series of “corrections” that were each individually presented as minor refinements.

The bold original claim — “All X are Y” — was wrong. Its wrongness was informative. It said: here is a strong hypothesis that was tested and failed. The failure tells us that the relationship between X and Y is more complex than universal association. The boundary between where the association holds and where it fails is the productive research territory.

The drifted version provides none of this information. It says that X and Y are sometimes associated, which tells the next investigator nothing about when, why, or how. The boundary that the original falsification revealed — the specific counterexample, the specific context in which the association fails — has been absorbed into successive scope reductions. The map coordinate has been moved so many times that it no longer marks any identifiable point.

Under the honest standard, the original paper dies at the first counterexample. “All X are Y” is a universal claim. One counterexample kills it. The counterexample is published as a falsification. A new paper claims “X are Y in contexts P and Q but not R.” The new paper is a new timestamp, a new coordinate, a new testable claim. If context S provides another counterexample, the new paper dies and a newer paper replaces it. Each death is a coordinate. Each coordinate marks a boundary. The map grows more precise through a chain of deaths and replacements, each one a fixed point in the record.

The drifted version has one coordinate that moves. The honest version has multiple coordinates that are fixed. The drifted version produces an increasingly vague claim that is immune to testing. The honest version produces an increasingly precise map of where the relationship holds and fails. The drifted version is less useful at every revision. The honest version is more useful at every death.

X. THE ERRATA STANDARD

Errata exists because humans are imperfect at transcription. A digit is mistyped. A reference is miscopied. A table heading is wrong. A formatting error obscures a decimal point. These are errors of transmission, not errors of claim.

The test for whether a change is errata or falsification is simple. Read the paper before the proposed change. Read it after. Does what the paper claims change?

If no — the paper's assertions, predictions, conclusions, and scope are identical before and after — the change is errata. The paper said what it meant. The transcription contained an error. Fix the transcription. The paper lives.

If yes — the paper's assertions, predictions, conclusions, or scope differ before and after — the change is not errata. The paper as published made a claim that does not hold. The paper is dead. Write a new one.

A CODATA reference value mistyped in a table that the paper's derivations do not use and that does not affect any claim the paper makes is errata. Fix the typo. The paper's meaning is unchanged.

A predicted value that disagrees with measurement is not errata. The paper committed to a specific prediction. The prediction was wrong. The paper meant what it said. What it said does not hold. The paper is dead regardless of how close the prediction was to the measurement. If the paper said 2.1 and reality said 2.2, the paper is dead. The paper meant 2.1. It was not a typo. The derivation produced 2.1. Reality produced 2.2. The gap between them is the falsification. The gap is the boundary. The gap is the information.

The institution's current errata system does not enforce this distinction. Errata that change conclusions, that revise predictions, that narrow scope are processed through the same mechanism as errata that fix typos. The distinction between transcription error and claim failure is not maintained. The result is that claim failures are processed as transcription errors — minor corrections to an essentially correct paper — and the falsification is absorbed without being recorded as a falsification.

The honest standard enforces the distinction absolutely. Does the meaning change? If yes, the paper is dead. No exceptions. No gradations. No "minor revision to conclusions." The claim was made. The claim was wrong. The death is the finding. Process it as a death, not as a correction.

XI. THE EXISTENCE PROOF

The CKS investigation, documented in [HOWL-INFO-5-2026], practiced the honest standard.

Three hundred and ninety papers were produced over 45 days. The mathematics was tested. The mathematics failed. The entire corpus was killed. Not patched. Not revised. Not corrected. Killed.

Every paper was marked as falsified. The falsification was timestamped. The dead papers remain in the public archive with their falsification markers. Anyone can read them. Anyone can see what was claimed and why it failed. The dead papers are coordinates on the map — they show where the investigation explored and where it hit boundaries.

The post-mortem — [HOWL-INFO-5-2026] itself — is a new publication standing on the falsification. It references the dead papers. It documents the failure mechanism. It extracts what survived. It makes new claims informed by the boundaries the falsification revealed. It is a new timestamp at a new coordinate, built on the ground the dead papers exposed.

The surviving content — metamathematical arguments with nonzero M-scores — was extracted into new papers with their own claims, their own evidence, and their own falsification conditions. These new papers are new coordinates. They stand on the dead papers' graves. They exist because the dead papers found the boundaries.

The chain is visible. Original claims, falsification, post-mortem, extraction, new claims. Every link is a timestamp. Every timestamp is fixed. The dead papers are dead. The living papers are alive. The record shows the full investigation — the exploration, the failure, the boundary, the recovery. Nothing has been edited. Nothing has been erased. The map is complete.

This is what the standard looks like when practiced. It is not hypothetical. It has been done. One investigator, one corpus, full cycle. The dead papers are more informative than they would have been if they had been patched to match reality, because their deaths document the coherence capture mechanism that [HOWL-INFO-5-2026] characterizes. The failure was the discovery. Patching would have erased the discovery. The honest standard preserved it.

XII. CONCLUSION

A scientific publication is immutable and mortal. It is a timestamp — a fixed commitment at a specific coordinate in the history of investigation. It says what was claimed, when, and on what basis. The timestamp does not move. The commitment does not change. The coordinate is permanent.

When the claim is wrong, the publication dies. Death means the claim as stated does not hold. The publication stays in the record, marked as falsified, pointing to what killed it. The death is information. The death is a boundary marker. The boundary tells every future investigator where this approach failed and what the failure reveals about where to look next.

Replacement is a new publication. It stands on the dead paper. It references the falsification. It makes a new claim informed by the boundary. The new claim is a new timestamp, a new coordinate, a new commitment. The chain — claim, falsification, boundary, new claim — is the mechanism by which science advances. Every link is essential. Every link is preserved.

Patching breaks the chain. It overwrites the dead coordinate with a revised one. It erases the boundary. It hides the failure. It produces retroactive infallibility — an institution that is never wrong because the record is edited until it matches reality. A patched publication is a prophecy, not a hypothesis — it matches observation because it was revised to match, not because it predicted correctly. By the institution's own demarcation criterion, a prophecy is not science.

The errata standard is simple. Does the paper's meaning change? If no, fix the typo. If yes, the paper is dead. No exceptions. No gradations. No revised conclusions. The claim was made. The claim was wrong. The death is the finding. Process it as a death.

Edison's 10,000 failures were 10,000 timestamps. Each one said: this material, this configuration, this approach, at this date, does not work. Each timestamp was permanent. None were revised to say "actually, this did work, we just needed to adjust the parameters." Each dead timestamp was a coordinate on the map. The map led to the working filament. The filament exists because the dead timestamps were preserved, not because they were edited into successes.

Publications are born. They live. They die. They stay. The honest standard asks only this: let them stay as they were, mark them when they fall, and build the next thing on the ground their death reveals. The corpse is the map. Do not edit the corpse. Do not remove the corpse. Do not pretend the corpse was always alive. Mark it, learn from it, and continue.

END HOWL-CULT-6-2026

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Central Argument: Publications are immutable timestamps; when wrong, they die and stay in the record as boundary markers; patching constitutes retroactive infallibility and converts hypotheses into prophecies

Key Demonstrations: The Neptune example done correctly versus patched; the slow drift from bold falsifiable claims to trivially true unfalsifiable ones; the CKS corpus as existence proof of the honest standard

Structural Finding: A patched publication is unfalsifiable by the institution's own demarcation criterion — it matches observation because it was edited to match, which is the definition of prophecy, which is the definition of what the institution claims to distinguish itself from

Conclusion: Publications are born, live, die, and stay; the corpse is the map; do not edit the corpse

[**HOWL-CULT-6-2026**] Immutable and Mortal. Github: https://github.com/ghowland/papers/tree/main/papers/CULT/HC
CULT-6-2026

[**HOWL-BODY-1-2026**] Neural Territory. Github: https://github.com/ghowland/papers/tree/main/papers/BODY/HOWL
BODY-1-2026

[**HOWL-CULT-1-2026**] The N=1000 Fallacy. Github: https://github.com/ghowland/papers/tree/main/papers/CULT/HOV
CULT-1-2026

[**HOWL-CULT-2-2026**] The Domain Boundary. Github: https://github.com/ghowland/papers/tree/main/papers/CULT/HO
CULT-2-2026

[**HOWL-CULT-3-2026**] The Falsification Forfeiture. Github: https://github.com/ghowland/papers/tree/main/papers/CUL
CULT-3-2026

[**HOWL-CULT-4-2026**] What Falsification Actually Requires. Github: https://github.com/ghowland/papers/tree/main/pap
CULT-4-2026

[**HOWL-CULT-5-2026**] Falsification as Finding. Github: https://github.com/ghowland/papers/tree/main/papers/CULT/HO
CULT-5-2026

[**HOWL-INFO-5-2026**] Coherence as Information Phenomenon. Github: https://github.com/ghowland/papers/tree/main/p
INFO-5-2026